

Telugu, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

Adhithya Rajasekaran

This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

Companion practice lessons live alongside this book at
code/learning/human-languages/telugu/lessons/

Copyright © Adhithya Rajasekaran. Licensed under Creative Commons
Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 International (CC BY-SA 4.0). Telugu set in
Noto Sans Telugu (SIL Open Font License).

Preface

This is the Telugu volume of a wider project, and it is written for someone starting from zero — who may not read a single Telugu letter — so the script is taught *inside the word lessons themselves*: each word introduces exactly the letters it needs, so you learn to read నమస్కారం *and* learn that it means “greetings” in the same few minutes. There is no alphabet drill to sit through first. (A reader who already reads Telugu simply skims the “letters in this word” notes.)

Telugu — famous as “the Italian of the East” for its open, vowel-final music — is one of the four literary **Dravidian** languages, a family entirely separate from the Indo-European one that gave us English, Latin, and Sanskrit. Like its sister Kannada, and unlike Tamil, it borrowed *heavily* from Sanskrit; so “hello” is the Sanskrit నమస్కారం (*namaskāram*), yet “yes” and “okay” are the native అవును (*avunu*) and సరే (*sarē*). Telugu also shows the family is no monolith: where its sisters say “no” with a word from the root *il-*, Telugu goes its own way with లేదు (*lēdu*). Each lesson sets the word beside its cousins across the family — English always, and Sanskrit, Hindi, and the other Dravidian languages where they illuminate — every form supplied in full, so no prior knowledge of any of them is assumed.

Same three commitments as the other volumes: one word per lesson, gone deep; the widest *honest* web of connections; the cultural reason, not just the rule. Released under CC BY-SA 4.0.

Contents

Preface	iii
The Telugu script (reference)	1
1 Greetings	3
1.1 నమస్కారం (<i>namaskāram</i>) — “greetings,” a making of a bow .	3
1.2 ధన్యవాదములు (<i>dhanyavādamulu</i>) — “thank you”	4
1.3 అవును (<i>avunu</i>) — “yes”	5
1.4 లేదు (<i>lēdu</i>) — “no,” where Telugu parts ways with its sisters .	5
1.5 సరే (<i>sarē</i>) — “okay,” the family word in Telugu dress	6
1.6 Recap, and how Telugu says goodbye	7
2 Introducing Yourself	9
2.1 పేరు (<i>pēru</i>) — “name,” the native Dravidian word	9
2.2 నా (<i>nā</i>) — “my”	10
2.3 నా పేరు ... (<i>nā pēru ...</i>) — “my name is...”	10
2.4 నువ్వు / మీరు (<i>nuvvu / mīru</i>) — “you,” familiar and respectful	11
2.5 ఏమిటి (<i>ēmiṭi</i>) — “what”	11
2.6 మీ పేరు ఏమిటి? (<i>mī pēru ēmiṭi</i>) — “what’s your name?” . . .	11
2.7 సంతోషం (<i>santōṣam</i>) — “joy,” and “pleased to meet you” . . .	12
2.8 The whole exchange	12
3 How Are You?	13
3.1 ఎలా (<i>elā</i>) — “how,” another of the e- questions	13
3.2 మీరు ఎలా ఉన్నారు? — “how are you?”	13
3.3 నేను (<i>nēnu</i>) — “I,” the Dravidian first person	14
3.4 బాగా (<i>bāgā</i>) — “well,” and how to answer	14
3.5 పరవాలేదు (<i>paravalēdu</i>) — “no problem”	15
3.6 The whole exchange	15

4	Farewells	17
4.1	వెళ్ళు (<i>vellu</i>) — “go,” and వచ్చు (come)	17
4.2	వెళ్ళి వస్తాను (<i>velli vastānu</i>) — “I’ll go and come back”	17
4.3	రేపు కలుద్దాం (<i>rēpu kaluddām</i>) — “see you tomorrow”	18
4.4	మళ్ళీ కలుద్దాం (<i>mallī kaluddām</i>) — “we’ll meet again”	18
4.5	The farewells	19
5	The First Verbs	21
5.1	మాట్లాడు (<i>māṭlāḍu</i>) — “to speak,” your first full verb	21
5.2	నేను తెలుగు మాట్లాడతాను — “I speak Telugu”	22
5.3	ఉండు (<i>undu</i>) — “to be, to stay, to live”	22
5.4	పని చేయు (<i>pani cēyu</i>) — “to work”	23
5.5	Sentences about yourself	23

The Telugu script — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach reading through real words, each letter introduced as a word needs it. This page just gathers the system.

The three facts

1. **Consonants carry a built-in “a.”** క = ka, మ = ma, ర = ra. (Many wear the *talakaṭṭu*, a small check-mark hat.)
2. **A vowel sign changes that built-in vowel.** కా = k̄ā, కి = k̄i, కే = k̄e, కు = k̄u, కూ = k̄ū, కె = k̄ē, కో = k̄o, కో = k̄ō.
3. **A *virama* strips the vowel, and the bare consonant *stacks below the next* as a conjunct.** స + క → స్క (ska), న + య → న్య (nya). A dot **anusvāra** ం adds a final nasal.

Independent vowels (word-initial)

అ a · ఆ ā · ఇ i · ఈ ī · ఉ u · ఊ ū · ఎ e · ఏ ē · ఐ ai · ఒ o · ఓ ō · ఔ au.

Worth flagging

- **Aspiration is written.** క k / ఖ kh, ద d / ధ dh — the “h” is a real puff. Like Kannada (and unlike Tamil), Telugu keeps the Sanskrit aspirates and voiced stops as separate letters, because it borrowed so many Sanskrit words.
- **Round, looping forms.** Telugu and Kannada are script-sisters, shaped for palm-leaf writing; the two look far more like each other than like Tamil.

Telugu in the Dravidian family

Dravidian is a family entirely separate from Indo-European (English, Latin, Sanskrit). Telugu shares grammar and native vocabulary with Tamil, Kannada, and Malayalam — but, like Kannada and unlike Tamil, it borrowed *heavily* from Sanskrit. It also shows the family is not uniform: where its sisters say “no” with a word from the root *il-*, Telugu uses its own *lēdu* / *kādu*. The lessons trace, word by word, what is home-grown and what is borrowed.

Chapter 1

Greetings

The Telugu greetings and the words that oil a first conversation — and, taught through them, how to read the Telugu script and how Telugu sits inside the Dravidian family. Each lesson introduces the letters its word needs, so you learn to read the word and understand it at once. *Practice lessons: lessons/TE-C01-*.md.*

1.1 నమస్కారం (*namaskāram*) — “greetings,” a making of a bow

The letters in this word

Telugu reads **left to right**, and every consonant carries a built-in “a” (many under a little check-mark hat, the *talakattu*). న na, మ ma, ర ra. A **vowel sign** changes it: క ka + long-ā → కా kā. A vowel-less consonant **stacks below** the next as a conjunct: స tucks under ka → స్క “ska.” And the **anusvāra** ం adds a final nasal “-m.” Read న·మ·స్·కా·ర·ం → *namaskāram*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

నమస్కారం (*namaskāram*) is **Sanskrit**: *namas* (“a bow, homage”) + *kāra* (“a making,” root *kr*, “to do”), with a Telugu ending = “the making of a bow.” The same word as Hindi *namaskār* and Kannada *namaskāra*. Telugu borrowed *heavily* from Sanskrit — often called the most Sanskritised Dravidian tongue — where its sister Tamil kept the home-grown *vaṇakkam*.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“Hello”	Source
Telugu	నమస్కారం <i>namaskāram</i>	Sanskrit
Kannada	<i>namaskāra</i>	Sanskrit
Malayalam	<i>namaskāram</i>	Sanskrit
Hindi	<i>namaste</i>	Sanskrit
Tamil	<i>vaṇakkam</i>	native Dravidian
English	<i>hello</i>	Germanic

Tamil alone kept its own word.

Why it’s said this way

Said with the palms pressed together and a small bow — the gesture *is* the word. Both **hello** and **goodbye**, any time, to almost anyone.

1.2 ధన్యవాదములు (*dhanyavādamulu*) — “thank you”

The letters in this word

New: ధ *dha* (aspirated *d*), the conjunct న్న (*na* stacked with *ya*), then వా·ద·ము·లు. Read ధ·న్య·వా·ద·ము·లు → *dhanyavādamulu*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The core is **Sanskrit**: *dhanya* (“worthy,” from *dhana*, “wealth”) + *vāda* (“a saying,” root *vad*). Telugu adds its own **plural ending -mulu**, so *dhanyavāda-mulu* = “worthy-sayings,” thanks in the plural of courtesy (also the shorter *dhanyavādālu*). Same Sanskrit stem as Hindi *dhanyavād*.

Grammar Lens

Telugu builds words by gluing endings on. *-mulu* is your first taste of Dravidian *agglutination*: meaning is stacked by suffixes on a stem, not by separate little words. Later endings mark case (“to,” “from,” “with”) the same way. In Telugu, grammar is mostly **suffixes**.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways		
Language	“Thanks”	Note
Telugu	ధన్యవాదములు <i>dhanyavādamulu</i>	Sanskrit stem + Telugu plural
Kannada	<i>dhanyavāda</i>	Sanskrit — same stem
Hindi	<i>dhanyavād</i>	Sanskrit — same stem
Tamil	<i>nanri</i>	native (“goodness”)
Malayalam	<i>nandi</i>	native

1.3 అవును (*avunu*) — “yes”

The letters in this word

అ is the **independent vowel** “a” (word-initial). వు is *vu*, ను is *nu* (each a consonant with the “u” sign). Read అ·వు·ను → *avunu*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

అవును (*avunu*) is the everyday native “yes / it is so” — close at root to the verb of being, which is why its “no” partner *kādu* (“is not”) is its exact mirror.

Grammar Lens

Telugu’s yes/no are little **statements of being**: *avunu* (“it is [so]”) vs. *kādu* (“it is not”). A Dravidian instinct — answer by asserting or denying existence, not with a bare particle. You’ll also hear a “yes” echoed as the question’s own verb.

1.4 లేదు (*lēdu*) — “no,” where Telugu parts ways with its sisters

The letters in this word

లే is *lē* (ల *la* with the long-“ē” sign); దు is *du*. Read లే·దు → *lēdu*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

లేదు (*lēdu*) means “there is not, it is absent” — native Dravidian, but on a **different root** (*lē-*) from the *il-* of Tamil and Kannada. Telugu also has కాదు (*kādu*), “it is not [that],” so it splits “no” in two: *lēdu* denies **existence** (*pustakam lēdu*, “there is no book”); *kādu* denies **identity** (*idi pustakam kādu*, “this is not a book”).

Grammar Lens

Two “no”s, existence vs. identity. English leans on one flat “no”; Telugu keeps *lēdu* (“there isn’t”) and *kādu* (“isn’t that”). Choosing between them is choosing *what* you deny — a Dravidian trait Telugu draws most sharply, and with a different root-word from its sisters.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“No / isn’t”	Note
Telugu	లేదు / కాదు <i>lēdu</i> / <i>kādu</i>	native, different root
Tamil	<i>illai</i>	native, root <i>il-</i>
Kannada	<i>illa</i>	native, root <i>il-</i>
Malayalam	<i>illa</i>	native, root <i>il-</i>
Hindi	<i>nahīm</i>	Indo-European (unrelated)

Three sisters share *il-*; Telugu alone picked *lē-* / *kā-* — the family is real, but not uniform.

1.5 సరి (*sarē*) — “okay,” the family word in Telugu dress

The letters in this word

స is *sa*; రి is *rē* (ర *ra* with the long-“ē” sign you just met on *lē*). Read స·రి → *sarē*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

సరి (*sarē*) is native Dravidian “correct, right” → “okay, agreed” — the verbal nod of Telugu. It is the same family word as Tamil and Kannada

sari, worn to *sarē*; doubled, *sarē sarē* = “alright, alright.”

Grammar Lens

One Dravidian word, three scripts. *sari* / *sarē* is essentially one word and meaning dressed in Tamil, Kannada, and Telugu letters. Spotting a shared word change its shape but not its sense is the fastest way to feel the family — and the whole point of learning these four side by side.

1.6 Recap, and how Telugu says goodbye

Read		Meaning	Origin
నమస్కారం	<i>namaskāram</i>	hello	Sanskrit
ధన్యవాదములు	<i>dhanyavādamulu</i>	thank you	Sanskrit + Telugu plural
అవును	<i>avunu</i>	yes	native
లేదు	<i>lēdu</i>	no / isn’t	native (root <i>lē-</i> , not <i>il-</i>)
సరే	<i>sarē</i>	okay	native (= <i>sari</i>)

The familiar pattern — Sanskrit for the greetings, native for the everyday grammar — with Telugu’s own twist: its “no” takes a different native root from its sisters.

Why it’s said this way

The same “go and come back.” Telugu, too, avoids a bare “I’m leaving.” The everyday goodbye is వెళ్ళి వస్తాను (*velli vastānu*), “having gone, I [will] come [back],” with the reply వెళ్ళి రండి (*veli raṇḍi*), “go, and come back” — the worldview you met in Tamil’s *pōy varugirēn* and Kannada’s *hōgi baruttēne*.

Next chapter: introducing yourself — *nā pēru...* (“my name...”) — and Telugu’s *nuvvu* / *mīru* (familiar / respectful “you”).

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Now a first real exchange — giving your name, asking for someone else’s, and saying you’re glad to meet them:

నా పేరు అరుణ్. (nā pēru Arun — “My name is Arun.”)
మీ పేరు ఏమిటి? (mī pēru ēmiṭi — “What is your name?”)

Built the same way as the greetings — each piece taken apart, its letters and its root, then assembled. *Practice lessons: lessons/TE-C02-*.md.*

2.1 పేరు (pēru) — “name,” the native Dravidian word

The letters in this word

ప (pa) + ే (the ē-sign) → పే (pē); రు (ru). Read పే·రు → pēru.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

పేరు (pēru, “name”) is **native Dravidian**, from Proto-Dravidian *pēr — the *same* word as Tamil *peyar* and Malayalam *pēr*, and a cousin of Kannada *hesaru* (which softened the old *p* to *h*). It is *not* the Sanskrit *nāma* (Hindi *nām*, English *name*). Even in Telugu — the most Sanskritised of the Dravidian tongues — the everyday word for “name” stayed home-grown.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“Name”	Source
Telugu	పేరు <i>pēru</i>	native Dravidian (*pēr)
Tamil	<i>peyar</i>	the <i>same</i> Dravidian root
Malayalam	<i>pēr</i>	the <i>same</i> Dravidian root
Kannada	<i>hesaru</i>	Dravidian (*pesar, p→h)
Hindi	<i>nām</i>	Sanskrit (Indo-European)
English	<i>name</i>	Indo-European

2.2 నా (*nā*) — “my”

The letters in this word

న (*na*) + ా (long ā) → నా (*nā*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

నా (*nā*, “my”) is the possessive of నేను (*nēnu*, “I”) — native Dravidian, on the pronoun stem *nān/*yān behind Tamil *nān* and Kannada *nānu*. No Indo-European cousin: the Dravidian “I/my” is a wholly different word from the European *I/my*.

2.3 నా పేరు ... (*nā pēru ...*) — “my name is...”

నా (my) + పేరు (name) + name = **nā pēru ...** *Nā pēru Arun.* = “My name is Arun.”

Grammar Lens

No word for “is.” As in Tamil and Kannada, there is *no* verb: Telugu sets “my name” beside “Arun” and lets the “is” be understood — the **zero copula** of the Dravidian family. *Nā pēru Arun* = literally “my name Arun.”

2.4 నువ్వు / మీరు (*nuvvu* / *mīru*) — “you,” familiar and respectful

The letters in this word

నువ్వు (*nuvvu*); మీరు (*mīru*, మీ *mī* + రు *ru*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

నువ్వు (*nuvvu*, familiar “you”) traces to Proto-Dravidian *nīn — the same native root as Tamil *nī* and Kannada *nīnu*. మీరు (*mīru*) is the respectful/plural “you.”

Grammar Lens

Respect by the plural, again. *nuvvu* (familiar) vs. *mīru* (respectful, and literally plural) — the same politeness-by-plural as Tamil *nīṅgaḷ*, Kannada *nīvu*, and French *vous*. For a first meeting, *mīru*.

2.5 ఏమిటి (*ēmiṭi*) — “what”

The letters in this word

ఏ (independent long ē) + మి (*mi*) + టి (*ṭi*, retroflex) → *ēmiṭi*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ఏమిటి (*ēmiṭi*, “what”) is native Dravidian, on the interrogative stem *yā-/*e- — the same Dravidian question-root as Tamil *enna* and Kannada *ēnu*, heading Telugu’s question family: *ēmiṭi* (what), *evaru* (who), *ekkaḍa* (where), *enduku* (why).

2.6 మీ పేరు ఏమిటి? (*mī pēru ēmiṭi*) — “what’s your name?”

మీ (*mī*, “your”) is the possessive of *mīru* (“you,” respectful). So మీ పేరు ఏమిటి? is literally “**your name what?**” — and again *no* “*is*.” Three words, no verb.

Grammar Lens

Answer with the sentence you built: *Nā pēru Arun*. The familiar “your” is *nī* (from *nuvvu*): *nī pēru ēmiṭi?*

2.7 సంతోషం (*santōṣam*) — “joy,” and “pleased to meet you”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The warm close is మిమ్మల్ని కలిసినందుకు సంతోషం (*mimmalni kalisinanduku santōṣam*) — “joy at having met you.” The key word సంతోషం (*santōṣam*, “joy, gladness”) is **Sanskrit** (*sam-* + *toṣa*, “full satisfaction”), the *same* loan Kannada uses — both reach for Sanskrit where Tamil keeps its native *magilecci*. Telugu, the most Sanskritised of the four, does so most readily of all.

2.8 The whole exchange

Telugu		English
నా పేరు మీరా.	<i>nā pēru Mira</i>	My name is Mira.
మీ పేరు ఏమిటి?	<i>mī pēru ēmiṭi</i>	What’s your name?
నా పేరు అరుణ్.	<i>nā pēru Arun</i>	My name is Arun.
సంతోషం.	<i>santōṣam</i>	Pleased to meet you.

Every atom traced: *pēru* (Dravidian *pēr, *not name*), *nā* (from *nēnu*, “I”), *ēmiṭi* (Dravidian question-stem) — and *santōṣam*, a Sanskrit loan for “pleased.” The Telugu habit: the **zero copula** (no “is”). Next chapter: *elā unnāru?* (“how are you?”) and answering with *bāgunnānu* — the responding cycle.

Chapter 3

How Are You?

After the name comes the exchange everyone actually has — and, for the first time, a Telugu verb “to be”:

మీరు ఎలా ఉన్నారు? (*mīru elā unnāru* — “How are you?”)
నేను బాగున్నాను, ధన్యవాదములు. (*nēnu bāgunnānu, dhanyavādamulu* —
“I’m well, thank you.”)

Practice lessons: lessons/TE-C03-.md.*

3.1 ఎలా (*elā*) — “how,” another of the e- questions

The letters in this word

ఎ (independent short e) + లా (*lā*) → ఎలా (*elā*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ఎలా (*elā*, “how”) is native Dravidian, on the interrogative base ఎ- (*e-*) from *ēmiṭi*. Telugu gathers nearly all its questions under this **e-**: *ēmiṭi* (what), *elā* (how), *evāru* (who), *ekkāḍa* (where), *eppuḍu* (when). It is the same Dravidian question-root heading Tamil’s *eppaṭi* and Kannada’s *ēnu* — a family older than the Sanskrit words Telugu otherwise borrows so freely.

3.2 మీరు ఎలా ఉన్నారు? — “how are you?”

The new word is ఉన్నారు (*unnāru*, “you are”): from the verb ఉండు (*unḍu*, “to be, exist, stay”) + the respectful-you ending *-āru*. So మీరు ఎలా ఉన్నారు? is “you how are?”, the verb last, as in every Telugu sentence.

Grammar Lens

The verb carries “you.” The ending *-āru* already means “you (respectful),” so *mīru* can be dropped: *elā unnāru?* is a whole “how are you?” To a friend: నువ్వు ఎలా ఉన్నావు? (*nuvvu elā unnāvu?* — *-āvu* for the familiar “you”). Match the “you” to the verb-ending.

3.3 నేను (*nēnu*) — “I,” the Dravidian first person**The letters in this word**

నే (*nē*) + ను (*nu*) → నేను (*nēnu*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

నేను (*nēnu*, “I”) ← Proto-Dravidian **yān* / **nēn* — native, and (unlike Hindi’s *maiṃ*, cousin of English *me*) **not** related to the European “I/me” family. Its possessive is the నా (*nā*, “my”) you met in Chapter 2. For all the Sanskrit Telugu borrows elsewhere, its basic pronouns stayed Dravidian to the core.

3.4 బాగా (*bāgā*) — “well,” and how to answer**The letters in this word**

బా (*bā*) + గా (*gā*) → బాగా (*bāgā*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

బాగా (*bāgā*, “well, nicely, very”), from బాగు (*bāgu*, “goodness”), is the everyday “well/good/very.” To answer “how are you,” fuse it with the *uṇḍu* verb: నేను బాగున్నాను (*nēnu bāgunnānu*, “I am well” — *bāgā* + *unnānu* run together).

3.5 పరవాలేదు (*paravalēdu*) — “no problem”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

పరవాలేదు literally “**there is no harm**” — *paravā* (“harm”) + లేదు (*lēdu*, “is-not”), the Chapter-1 negative. It serves as “it’s okay / no worries / you’re welcome.” The atom లేదు (*lēdu*) is where Telugu goes its own way: Tamil, Kannada, and Malayalam all say *illa(i)* for “is-not,” but **Telugu alone** uses *lēdu* — so Tamil’s “no problem” is *paravāyillai*, Telugu’s is *paravalēdu*, the same idea on each language’s own “not.”

Grammar Lens

లేదు (*lēdu*) negates existence: *ḍabbu lēdu* (“there’s no money”). It is the negative twin of ఉంది (*undi*, “there is”) and of the *uṇḍu* verb behind “how are you.” Hold *undi* / *lēdu* together — “there is” and “there is not.”

3.6 The whole exchange

Telugu	English
మీరు ఎలా ఉన్నారు?	How are you?
నేను బాగున్నాను, ధన్యవాదములు.	I’m well, thank you.
పరవాలేదు.	No problem / you’re welcome.

Every atom traced: *elā* (the native *e*- questions), *nēnu* (Proto-Dravidian, unrelated to *me*), *bāgā* (“well”), and the *undi* / *lēdu* pair — “there is” and “there is not,” Telugu’s own “not” where its sisters use *illa*. Next chapter: the farewells — and Telugu, like all its family, never says a plain “goodbye.”

Chapter 4

Farewells

Telugu, like every Dravidian language, does not say a plain “goodbye.” It promises to return:

వెళ్ళి వస్తాను. (*velli vastānu* — “I’ll go and come back.”)

Practice lessons: *lessons/TE-C04-*.md*.

4.1 వెళ్ళు (*vellu*) — “go,” and వచ్చు (come)

The letters in this word

వె (*ve*) + ళ్ళు (*llu*, doubled retroflex శ *l*) → వెళ్ళు. Its partner వచ్చు (*vaccu*, “come”).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

వెళ్ళు (*vellu*, “to go”) and వచ్చు (*vaccu*, “to come”) are native Dravidian verbs. As commands they are whole words: *vellu!* (“go!”), *rā!* (“come!”). You need both, because Telugu’s goodbye is “I go, and I come back.”

4.2 వెళ్ళి వస్తాను (*velli vastānu*) — “I’ll go and come back”

వెళ్ళి (*velli*, “having gone”) + వస్తాను (*vastānu*, “I come”) — literally “**having gone, I come [back]**,” i.e. “I’ll go and come back.” A Telugu speaker never signs off with a bare “I’m leaving.” The warm reply is వెళ్ళి రండి (*velli raṇḍi*, “go and come [back]”).

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“go and come back” (goodbye)
Telugu	<i>velli vastānu</i>
Tamil	<i>pōy varugiṛēṇ</i>
Kannada	<i>hōgi baruttēne</i>
Malayalam	<i>pōyi varām</i>
Bengali (Indo-Aryan)	<i>āshi</i> (“I come”)

The whole south, and beyond, prefers a promise of return to a blunt farewell.

4.3 రేపు కలుద్దాం (*rēpu kaluddām*) — “see you tomorrow”

The letters in this word

రే (*rē*) + పు (*pu*) → రేపు. కలుద్దాం (*kaluddām*) = *kalu* (“meet”) + *-ddām* (“let’s”).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

రేపు (*rēpu*, “tomorrow”) is native; కలు (*kalu*, “to meet, join”) gives *kaluddām* (“let’s meet”) — “tomorrow, let’s meet.” The -దాం (*-ddām*) ending is Telugu’s “let’s ...”: *vellddām* (“let’s go”), *tindām* (“let’s eat”).

4.4 మళ్ళీ కలుద్దాం (*maḷḷī kaluddām*) — “we’ll meet again”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

మళ్ళీ కలుద్దాం = మళ్ళీ (*maḷḷī*, “again”) + *kaluddām* (“let’s meet”). Both are native Dravidian: *maḷḷī* (from *maral*, “to return”) and *kalu* (“meet”). Where Tamil’s “we’ll meet again” reaches for the Sanskrit loan *sandi* to say “meet,” Telugu keeps the native *kalu* — the same phrase, from different stock.

4.5 The farewells

Telugu	English
వెళ్ళి వస్తాను.	I'll go and come back. (goodbye)
వెళ్ళి రండి.	Go and come back. (the reply)
రేపు కలుద్దాం.	See you tomorrow.
మళ్ళీ కలుద్దాం.	We'll meet again.

Roots banked: *vellu/vaccu* (go/come), *rēpu* (“tomorrow”), *kalu* (“meet,” native — where Tamil borrowed *sandi*), and *mallī* (“again”). Next chapter: the first real verbs — *nēnu telugu māṭlāḍatānu* — and Telugu’s sentences begin to move.

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Until now, “to be” and “to be-not.” Now verbs that *act* — and Telugu’s sentences begin to move:

నేను తెలుగు మాట్లాడతాను. (*nēnu telugu māṭlāḍatānu* — “I speak Telugu.”)

Practice lessons: lessons/TE-C05-.md.*

5.1 మాట్లాడు (*māṭlāḍu*) — “to speak,” your first full verb

The letters in this word

మా (*mā*) + ట్లా (*tlā*) + డు (*ḍu*) → మాట్లాడు.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

మాట్లాడు (*māṭlāḍu*, “to speak”) is native Dravidian, built on మాట (*māṭa*, “word, speech”). To say “I speak,” Telugu stacks two endings on the stem — tense then person:

māṭlāḍ- + *-t-* (present) + *-ānu* (“I”) → మాట్లాడతాను (*māṭlāḍatānu*), “I speak.”

The *-ānu* ending is “I,” so *nēnu* is rarely needed: *māṭlāḍtāḍu* (he), *māṭlāḍtundi* (she/it), *māṭlāḍtāru* (they / you-respectful).

Grammar Lens

Stem + tense + person. Every Telugu verb is built this way. And, like Tamil, Telugu marks **no gender in the first person**: *māṭḷāḍatānu* is the same for a man or a woman — unlike Hindi’s *boltā/boltī*.

5.2 నేను తెలుగు మాట్లాడతాను — “I speak Telugu”

నేను (I) + తెలుగు (*telugu*, the object) + మాట్లాడతాను (speak) — “I Telugu speak,” verb last. The name తెలుగు (*telugu*) is native, of debated origin; its vowel-rich sound and habit of ending most words in a vowel earned it the old nickname “**the Italian of the East**.” It is the tongue of the *Kāvya* poets and of some eighty million speakers today.

Grammar Lens

No gender on “I speak.” *Māṭḷāḍatānu* is the same whether a man or a woman says it — Telugu, like Tamil, marks no gender in the first or second person (only the third: *-āḍu* he, *-undi* she/it).

5.3 ఉండు (*uṇḍu*) — “to be, to stay, to live”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ఉండు (*uṇḍu*, “to be, exist, stay, live”) is native Dravidian and does enormous work: it is the verb behind Chapter 3’s *unnāru* (“you are”) and *bāgunnānu* (“I’m well”), and it also means “to reside”: నేను హైదరాబాద్‌లో ఉంటాను (*nēnu Hyderābād̥lō uṇṭānu*, “I live in Hyderabad”). One verb covers “be,” “stay,” and “live.”

Grammar Lens

“In” comes after the noun. హైదరాబాద్‌లో (*Hyderābād̥lō*) = *Hyderabad* + -లో (*-lō*, “in”), glued to the *end* of the noun. Telugu uses **postpositions** (case-suffixes) where English uses prepositions: “Hyderabad-in I stay,” the verb last.

5.4 పని చేయు (*pani cēyu*) — “to work”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

చేయు (*cēyu*, “to do, make”) is a core native verb, and Telugu — like Hindi with *karnā* and Tamil with *sey* — builds compounds by putting a noun in front of it: పని చేయు (*pani cēyu*, “work-do” = “to work”), *vaṇṭa cēyu* (“to cook”), *sahāyaṃ cēyu* (“to help,” with a **Sanskrit** noun on the **native** *cēyu* — the two vocabularies in one verb). So “I work” is నేను పని చేస్తాను (*nēnu pani cēstānu*).

Grammar Lens

Noun + చేయు = a new verb — the exact twin of Hindi’s “noun + *karnā*” and Tamil’s “noun + *sey*.” Three languages, two of them from unrelated families, all landed on the same trick.

5.5 Sentences about yourself

Telugu	English
నేను తెలుగు మాట్లాడతాను.	I speak Telugu.
నేను హైదరాబాద్‌లో ఉంటాను.	I live in Hyderabad.
నేను పని చేస్తాను.	I work.

Three verbs, one engine: a stem, a tense-marker, a person-ending, the verb always last — and no gender in the first person. Roots banked: *māṭṭlāḍu* (speak ← *māṭa* “word”), *uṇḍu* (be/stay/live, with *-lō* “in” on the noun’s end), and *cēyu* (do → *pani cēyu* “to work,” the twin of Hindi’s *karnā*). From here, Telugu’s sentences only grow.